

WE ARE IN THE OPENING PHASE OF A MASS EXTINCTION

BIODIVERSITY HOTSPOTS

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Norman Myers (1934–2019)

BEFORE

1950 Theodosius Dobzhansky studies plant diversity in the tropics.

AFTER

2000 Myers and collaborators reevaluate the list of hotspots and add several new ones, bringing the total to 25.

2003 An article in *American Scientist* criticizes the concentration of conservation effort on hotspots, saying that this neglects less species-rich but still important “coldspots.”

2011 A team of researchers confirm the forests of east Australia as the 35th hotspot.

2016 The North American coastal plain is recognized as meeting the criteria for a global biodiversity hotspot—and becomes the 36th.

A biodiversity hotspot is an area with an unusually high concentration of animal and plant species. The term was coined in 1988 by Norman Myers, a British conservationist, to describe areas that are both biologically rich and